

The bar & the board — how this makes money

Why the platform fees are deliberately not the business, where the €10k/month actually comes from, and why radical transparency is the insurance on the revenue engine — not the brake on it.

The model in one sentence: the rails run at cost — fees are priced to cover an efficient infrastructure, fostering a more open, varied, fast and *not money-hungry* ecosystem of projects looking for teams and teams looking for projects — and welance earns by **winning work on its own board, openly**, as one team among many, at the same fees, behind the same blindness, judged by the same open bar. **At cost on the rails; earning on the field, never at the tollbooth.**

01 What we built

The Brief Bar (<code>briefs.welance.com</code>) An open, versioned ruleset that scores digital product briefs (0–100) and gates publication (4 hard requirements). Deterministic code owns every number; an LLM only judges. MIT, self-hostable, free console, MCP server — the bar lives inside the assistant people already write briefs with.	welance/Directory (<code>the board</code>) A blind noticeboard: clients post briefs ≥ €10k free; teams pitch anonymously (€10 refundable deposit); identities reveal only on a mutual handshake (€10 each side); optional paid Rebrief (team-quoted scoping, platform keeps a flat €10). Never a percentage of the work.
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02 The fact that decides everything: fees cannot be the business

Maximum platform take per fully-engaged transaction: **€30** (€20 handshake + €10 rebrief fee). To make €10k/month from fees alone:

PATH	ENGAGEMENTS /MO NEEDED	BRIEFS /MO NEEDED	VERDICT
Current fees	~450	350+	fantasy at 5+ years
Fees × 5 (€100 handshake)	~90	~70	still unreachable — and the “0.2% to open, 0% on the work” story burns

Conclusion: fee levels are irrelevant to revenue at any honest or dishonest price.
Their real job: spam filtering, skin in the game, and covering the rails — an efficient, stateless infrastructure whose running costs (cluster, Redis, judge calls, Stripe) are small.

So the fee story we tell is the true one: **priced to cover the rails, and we publish what the rails cost** (annual open cost ledger). Two adjustments only: one handshake fee (€10) everywhere — the €5 tier goes — and pitch deposits become uncaptured authorization holds, so the charge+refund cycle stops bleeding ~€0.40 of Stripe fees per pitch.

03 The engine: the two doors, declared

The method page already names them. **Door one** — the Directory: do it yourselves, the platform takes its €20–30 of rails fees. **Door two** — welance: we do it with you; welance composes and answers for the team, priced by the published split (70/30 at full autonomy). The engine is door two running *through* door one: welance pitches on the board like any other team, wins some briefs, and earns the coordination share — openly, at the same fees, under the same anonymity until reveal.

	~MONTH 6	~MONTH 12–18	FEES-ONLY (CONTRAST)
Quality briefs published /mo	8	20	350+
Platform fees (handshakes + rebrief fees)	~€220	~€550	€10,000
Briefs won by welance (30% split on avg €18k)	1 → €5,400	2 → €10,800	—
Rebriefs performed by welance (~€250 each)	1 → €250	2 → €500	—
Total /mo	~€5,900	~€11,900 ✓	unreachable

Assumptions: average brief €18k · ~1.2 handshakes per published brief · ~25% rebrief attach rate · welance pitches on roughly half the briefs and wins ~2 in 10 of those. All numbers are targets to verify, not promises.

the whole plan in one number

2 won briefs per month = the €10k/month target. Everything else — fees, tiers, pricing — is noise.

04 The single KPI, and how the free tool feeds it

KPI: quality briefs published per month (demand side). It is the only bottleneck; today nothing in either repo addresses client acquisition. The bet we've already built: briefs are written with AI assistants now, so the bar lives *inside the assistant* — `llms.txt`, the MCP server, the free console. A founder drafting a brief with their assistant gets scored against our bar, gets free suggestions, ends with a brief that clears the gate — and a one-click path to post it on the board. Every exit stays open (MIT, self-host, offline mock, no signup, nothing retained): that is what makes it a **declared interest instead of a trap**.

05 The Rebrief stays — it's the only scalable paid product

Paid scope-shaping, quoted by the team (anchor: 2× blended hourly), platform keeps a flat €10 regardless of quote. The golden rule is already coded: *the rebriefing team is barred from pitching on that brief* — paid for honest thinking, not for an audition. It binds welance too. What changes: the vetting gate (M11) stops manufacturing Rebrief demand. A brief that passes the Brief Bar's gate is vetted — **free, instant, automated**. The Rebrief becomes what it claims to be: optional professional help people choose, not a €295 express lane out of a waiting room we built.

06 Why radical honesty is load-bearing, not decorative

If the revenue engine is “we win work on our own board”, it has exactly one catastrophic failure mode: **the rigged-race scandal**. One credible accusation that the operator tilted the field and the engine is dead — dealflow, reputation, recruiting, all of it. So the transparency work ships *before* the growth push, in this order:

- **The disclosure that's currently missing:** “welance also pitches as a team — same fees, same blindness, same gate” — on the landing page, the rules page, and next to the publish button. Said where the objection lands.
 - **The Operator Covenant:** written commitments that bind the house, not the users — no lead-mining from briefs, no training on briefs, no sales contact derived from brief content, stated retention limits, call transcripts delivered to both parties by default. Testable in CI where code can test it (we already do this for BYOK keys); named plainly where it can't.
 - **The open bar as structural proof:** public versioned rules (can't be moved silently), verdicts carrying verbatim quotes (inspectable forever), a public test corpus in CI (no silent re-tuning), house policy explicitly labeled context: `directory`. The conflict of interest is not the project's shame — **it is the reason the bar must be open**.
 - **Winning and losing in public:** the participation log shows every pitch, every loss. Two wins a month on a board where everyone can see us lose is marketing no competitor can buy.
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07 What we never do

- ✗ Never a percentage of the work — the €10k+ engagement is theirs, uncut.
- ✗ Never pay-to-rank, paid visibility, or a preferred queue.
- ✗ Never wallets, credits, or anything that expires into thin air.
- ✗ Never mine briefs for leads, train on them, or contact anyone because of what a scored brief contained.
- ✗ Never a private bar: if we change the metre, the change is a public PR with a 7-day window and a test corpus that must move with it.
- ✗ Never price the rails as a profit centre: fees track running costs, and we publish the cost ledger so anyone can check the claim.

08 Roadmap

WHEN	WHAT
week 1	Truth-fixes on the public pages: uncollapse the conflict paragraph, add the “welance pitches too” disclosure, correct the data page, update governance.
weeks 2–3	Operator Covenant (+ CI test extension) · rename “Perfect Brief” → The Brief Bar · Directory doc rewrites (free instant vetting door, one fee, transcripts to both parties).
month 1	Deterministic gate checks (floor/title/PII) · adversarial “try to break the judge” test briefs · console: “draft check” vs “official verdict” labels.
months 1–3	The evidence: inter-rater agreement study (does the judge agree with humans?) and the validity study — re-score the 2012–2026 welance archive against known outcomes. Published either way.
after	The growth push: distribute the free bar, drive briefs/month, run the two-wins-a-month engine — on a field everyone can verify is level.

Fourth leg, optional, later: a hosted bar for agencies/procurement (custom ruleset + SLA, €200–500/mo). Demand is unproven — sell it before building it: three conversations, two yeses, or it doesn't exist.

welance · the brief bar × welance/Directory full analysis: perfect-brief-service/docs/critique/CRITIQUE.md